



Sofrito

COCINA BORICUA



La Mesa Boricua

30 essential Puerto Rican recipes from the Ortiz family kitchen — every dish bilingual, tested, and made to be cooked anywhere in the world.

LO QUE HAY DENTRO

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Plus: ingredient finder · pantry checklist · batch sofrito plan · holiday menu builder

BEFORE YOU COOK

The Ingredient Finder

Boricua cooking on the mainland. These swaps keep the flavor authentic when the original is hard to find.

Ingredient	What it is	Mainland swap
Culantro (recao)	Long-leaf herb — the backbone of sofrito	2 parts cilantro + 1 small green bell pepper
Ají dulce	Sweet, fruity little chili	Green bell pepper + pinch of habanero
Sazón	Seasoning blend for color & depth	¼ tsp each garlic powder, cumin, coriander + annatto
Adobo	All-purpose seasoning rub	Salt + garlic powder + pepper + oregano
Green plantains	Starchy, unripe — for tostones & mofongo	Most Latino grocers; green bananas in a pinch
Yautía & ñame	Root vegetables for sancocho & pasteles	Russet potato (flavor differs, texture holds)
Alcaparrado	Olives + capers + pimento	Green olives + capers
Gandules	Pigeon peas	Canned or frozen gandules at Latino grocers; dried chickpeas as a last resort

Pro tip: batch your sofrito and freeze it in ice-cube trays. One cube per dish — Monday's arroz con pollo tastes like abuela's Sunday.

STOCK ONCE, COOK FOR A MONTH

Pantry Checklist

Everything the 30 recipes call for. Print this page, cross it off, and a whole month of boricua dinners is one grocery trip away.

Staples

- ☐ Medium-grain rice (5 lb)
- ☐ Canned gandules (pigeon peas)
- ☐ Dried pink beans
- ☐ Coconut milk (unsweetened)
- ☐ Evaporated milk
- ☐ Condensed milk
- ☐ Cornmeal
- ☐ All-purpose flour

Seasoning drawer

- ☐ Garlic powder & fresh garlic
- ☐ Dried oregano
- ☐ Ground cumin & coriander
- ☐ Annatto (achiote) powder
- ☐ Black peppercorns
- ☐ Bay leaves
- ☐ Ground cinnamon
- ☐ Whole cloves & allspice

Cans & jars

- ☐ Tomato sauce (8 oz)
- ☐ Tomato paste
- ☐ Alcaparrado (olives + capers)
- ☐ Diced tomatoes
- ☐ Chicken & beef broth
- ☐ Olive oil & canola oil
- ☐ Distilled vinegar
- ☐ Rum (for coquito)

Fresh (weekly)

- ☐ Onions, red & yellow
- ☐ Green & red bell peppers
- ☐ Garlic head
- ☐ Cilantro & culantro
- ☐ Ripe & green plantains
- ☐ Calabaza (tropical pumpkin)
- ☐ Potatoes, russet
- ☐ Limes

Pro tip: dried pink beans hydrate overnight — no need to soak gandules, they simmer right in the rice pot.

The Batch Sofrito Plan

Sofrito is the soul of boricua cooking. Make a big batch once, and 25 of these recipes start with "one cube of sofrito."

Ingredient	Batch for 20 cubes
Culantro (recao)	3 large bunches
Cilantro	2 bunches
Ajíes dulces	20 (or 1 green bell pepper)
Green bell pepper	2, seeded
Red bell pepper	1, seeded
Yellow onion	2 large
Garlic	2 full heads
Olive oil	1/3 cup

The method

- 1 Wash everything, rough-chop.
- 2 Pulse in batches in the food processor — not to a paste, leave it rustic.
- 3 Sauté in the oil, then spoon into ice-cube trays.
- 4 Freeze solid, pop out, store in freezer bags.

One cube = one dish

- ☐ Arroz con pollo / gandules
- ☐ Pollo or carne guisada
- ☐ Habichuelas guisadas
- ☐ Picadillo
- ☐ Sancocho & mampostiao
- ☐ Bacalao guisado

Pro tip: frozen sofrito keeps 3 months. Label the bags — trust us, unlabeled frozen green cubes all look the same.

Holiday Menu Builder

The full Nochebuena table, from pork to dessert. Tick the boxes for your crowd — every dish lives in this cookbook.

Nochebuena (Christmas Eve) — feeds 10–14

- ☐ Pernil (page 20) — the centerpiece
- ☐ Arroz con Gandules (page 13)
- ☐ Ensalada de Coditos (page 33)
- ☐ Pasteles (page 30) — or 2 per guest, everyone wants one
- ☐ Coquito (page 31)
- ☐ Arroz con Dulce (page 32) — dessert to share

Timeline — the night before

- ☐ Marinate the pernil (12–24 hrs)
- ☐ Make the pasteles masa & filling, wrap and refrigerate
- ☐ Boil the coquito so it's chilled by tomorrow
- ☐ Soak nothing — gandules go straight in the rice

Christmas Day morning

- ☐ Roast the pernil at 300°F — walk away for 5 hours
- ☐ Set the rice pot to simmer with the gandules
- ☐ Steam the pasteles 1 hour before serving
- ☐ Crisp the pernil skin, make the coditos, pour the coquito

Pro tip: pernil can rest 45 minutes under foil and stay hot — crisp the skin at 450°F after carving off the top layer, so the pork below stays juicy.

Sofrito

The soul of boricua cooking — la base de todo

Makes: 20 cubes **Time:** 45 min **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

3 bunches culantro (recao)

2 bunches cilantro

20 ajíes dulces (or 1 green bell pepper)

2 green bell peppers, seeded

1 red bell pepper, seeded

2 large yellow onions

2 heads garlic, peeled

1/3 cup olive oil

STEPS

- 1 Wash and roughly chop all the herbs, peppers, onions and garlic.
- 2 Pulse in batches in a food processor — keep it rustic, not a paste.
- 3 Stir in the olive oil to help it freeze and release flavor.
- 4 Spoon into ice-cube trays and freeze solid, 3–4 hours.
- 5 Pop out the cubes and store in freezer bags up to 3 months.
- 6 Use one cube wherever a recipe says “sofrito.”

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Procesa el recao, culantro, ajíes, cebolla y ajo. Mezcla con aceite, vierte en bandejas de hielo y congela. Un cubito por plato — dura 3 meses.

Recaito

Green sofrito, no tomato — puro sabor verde

Makes: 2 cups **Time:** 20 min **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

2 bunches culantro

1 bunch cilantro

1 green bell pepper, seeded

1 yellow onion

8 garlic cloves

15 ajíes dulces (or extra green pepper)

¼ cup olive oil

Salt to taste

STEPS

- 1 Rough-chop the culantro, cilantro, pepper, onion and garlic.
- 2 Add half to the food processor and pulse; add the rest and pulse until minced.
- 3 Stir in the oil and salt. No heat — this stays raw and bright.
- 4 Keep refrigerated in a jar up to 1 week, or freeze in cubes.
- 5 Use where a dish wants green depth without tomato.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Sin tomate: culantro, ajíes, cebolla y ajo procesados con aceite. Se guarda crudo en la nevera o se congela.

Sazón

The color-and-flavor blend — el color de la cocina

Makes: ½ cup **Time:** 5 min **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

1 tbsp annatto (achiote) powder

1 tbsp garlic powder

1 tbsp ground cumin

2 tsp ground coriander

2 tsp dried oregano

1 tsp black pepper

1 tsp salt

STEPS

- 1 Combine every spice in a small bowl.
- 2 Whisk or shake to mix evenly.
- 3 Store in an airtight jar away from light, up to 6 months.
- 4 Use 1 packet-equivalent (2 tsp) per pot of rice or guiso.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Mezcla achiote, ajo en polvo, comino, cilantro seco, orégano, pimienta y sal. Dos cucharaditas por olla.

Adobo

The all-purpose rub — sazón para todo

Makes: ½ cup **Time:** 5 min **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

2 tbsp salt

1 tbsp garlic powder

1 tbsp black pepper

2 tsp dried oregano

1 tsp ground cumin (optional)

STEPS

- 1 Combine all the ingredients in a jar.
- 2 Shake to blend, then rub on meats before marinating or roasting.
- 3 Store in an airtight jar up to 6 months.
- 4 Season chicken, pork, and fish generously — it's the base rub.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Sal, ajo en polvo, pimienta y orégano. Se restriega sobre la carne antes de asar.

Mojo de Ajo

Garlic sauce — el compañero de todo frito

Makes: 1 cup **Time:** 15 min **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

1 head garlic, peeled

1 tsp salt

¼ tsp black pepper

½ cup olive oil

2 tbsp distilled vinegar (or lime juice)

1 tsp dried oregano

STEPS

- 1 Pound the garlic with salt into a rough paste (mortar or processor).
- 2 Warm the olive oil gently over low heat — don't brown the garlic.
- 3 Stir in the garlic paste, vinegar and oregano; heat 2 minutes.
- 4 Cool and bottle. Drizzle over tostones, mofongo, and roast pork.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Machaca el ajo con sal, calienta el aceite suave, mezcla todo con vinagre y orégano. Para tostones y mofongo.

Arroz Blanco

Perfect white rice — el pan de cada día

Makes: 6 servings **Time:** 25 min **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

2 cups medium-grain rice

3 cups water

2 tbsp olive oil

1 tsp salt

2 bay leaves (optional)

STEPS

- 1 Rinse the rice until the water runs clear, then drain well.
- 2 Heat the oil in a heavy pot; add the rice and toast 1–2 minutes.
- 3 Add water, salt and bay leaves. Bring to a full boil.
- 4 Lower the heat to the gentlest simmer, cover tightly, 15–18 minutes.
- 5 Remove from heat, leave covered 10 minutes. Fluff with a fork.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Lava el arroz, sofríelo en aceite, añade 3 tazas de agua y sal, tapa a fuego bajito 15–18 minutos. Deja reposar 10 y esponja.

Arroz con Gandules

The holiday classic — el arroz de fiesta

Makes: 8 servings **Time:** 45 min **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

3 cups medium-grain rice

1 can gandules (pigeon peas), drained,
liquid reserved

1 sofrito cube (page 7)

2 tsp sazón (page 10)

2 tbsp alcaparrado

1 ½ cups water + gandules liquid

3 tbsp olive oil

Salt & pepper

STEPS

- 1 Rinse and drain the rice.
- 2 Heat the oil; cook the sofrito cube 2 minutes until fragrant.
- 3 Add the rice, sazón and alcaparrado. Stir 3 minutes to coat.
- 4 Add gandules, then liquid (gandules liquid + water to reach 4½ cups total). Season with salt.
- 5 Boil, then cover and simmer low 20 minutes without lifting.
- 6 Rest 10 minutes off heat. Fluff and serve.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Sofríe el sofrito, saltea el arroz con sazón, añade los gandules con su jugo y agua hasta 4½ tazas. Tapa y cocina 20 minutos; reposa 10.

Arroz con Pollo

Yellow chicken & rice — el clásico de todos los domingos

Makes: 6 servings **Time:** 45 min **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

2 tbsp olive oil

1 sofrito cube (page 7)

6 bone-in chicken thighs, skin on

2 tsp sazón (page 10)

2 cups medium-grain rice

3 cups chicken broth, hot

½ cup alcaparrado

Salt, pepper & oregano

STEPS

- 1 Heat the oil over medium-high. Season the chicken with sazón, salt, pepper and oregano.
- 2 Brown the chicken, skin-side down, 4–5 minutes per side. Set aside.
- 3 In the same pot, cook the sofrito cube 2 minutes until fragrant.
- 4 Add the rice and stir to coat every grain. Add the alcaparrado.
- 5 Return the chicken to the pot, pour in the hot broth, bring to a boil.
- 6 Cover, lower the heat, and cook 20 minutes without lifting the lid.
- 7 Rest 5 minutes off the heat. Fluff and serve.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Dora el pollo con sazón. Sofríe el sofrito, saltea el arroz, vuelve a poner el pollo, añade el caldo caliente y tapa a fuego bajo por 20 minutos. Reposa 5 y esponja.

Mampostiao

Leftover rice reborn — el arroz de mañana

Makes: 4 servings **Time:** 20 min **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

3 cups leftover white rice

1 cup cooked pink beans (or canned habichuelas)

1 sofrito cube (page 7)

3 tbsp olive oil

½ cup bean cooking liquid or broth

Salt & pepper

STEPS

- 1 Heat the oil in a wide skillet; cook the sofrito cube 2 minutes.
- 2 Add the leftover rice and press it into the pan in an even layer.
- 3 Let it crisp on the bottom 4–5 minutes without stirring.
- 4 Fold in the beans and liquid; scrape up the crispy bits.
- 5 Cook 3 more minutes, season, and serve.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Con el arroz de ayer: sofríe el sofrito, dora el arroz en aceite sin moverlo, añade las habichuelas con su jugo y mezcla. Listo en 20.

Arroz con Salchichas

One-pot comfort — el favorito de los niños

Makes: 6 servings **Time:** 35 min **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

2 cups medium-grain rice

1 can Vienna sausages (or 4 smoked links, sliced)

1 sofrito cube (page 7)

½ cup tomato sauce

2 tsp sazón (page 10)

3 cups water

3 tbsp olive oil

STEPS

- 1 Rinse the rice and drain.
- 2 Heat the oil; cook the sofrito cube 2 minutes, then add tomato sauce and sazón.
- 3 Add the rice and stir 3 minutes until coated in red.
- 4 Add the sausages and water; bring to a boil.
- 5 Cover and simmer low 20 minutes without lifting.
- 6 Rest 10 minutes, fluff, and serve.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Igual que el arroz blanco, pero sofríes el sofrito con salsa de tomate y añades las salchichas al agua. 20 minutos tapado y listo.

Habichuelas Guisadas

Stewed pink beans — el acompañante eterno

Makes: 6 servings **Time:** 40 min **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

1 lb dried pink beans (or 2 cans)

1 sofrito cube (page 7)

½ cup tomato sauce

2 tsp sazón (page 10)

½ cup calabaza, cubed

2 potatoes, cubed (optional)

2 tbsp alcaparrado

3 cups water or broth

3 tbsp olive oil

STEPS

- 1 If using dried beans: soak overnight, simmer 1½ hours until tender. Drain, reserve 3 cups of cooking liquid.
- 2 Heat the oil; cook the sofrito cube 2 minutes.
- 3 Add tomato sauce, sazón and alcaparrado; cook 3 minutes.
- 4 Add beans, calabaza, potatoes and liquid. Simmer uncovered 20 minutes.
- 5 Simmer longer for a thicker sauce. Season and serve over rice.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Sofríe el sofrito con salsa de tomate, añade las habichuelas, calabaza, papa y agua. Hierva suave 20–25 minutos hasta espesar.

Pollo Guisado

Stewed chicken — comida de casa

Makes: 6 servings **Time:** 50 min **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

3 lb chicken, bone-in pieces

1 sofrito cube (page 7)

1 cup tomato sauce

2 tsp sazón (page 10)

2 potatoes, quartered

1 cup calabaza, cubed

2 tbsp alcaparrado

2 cups chicken broth

3 tbsp olive oil

STEPS

- 1 Season the chicken with sazón, salt and pepper.
- 2 Brown the chicken in oil, 5–6 minutes, in batches. Set aside.
- 3 Cook the sofrito cube 2 minutes; add tomato sauce and alcaparrado.
- 4 Return the chicken with the broth. Simmer, covered, 20 minutes.
- 5 Add potatoes and calabaza; simmer 15 more minutes until tender.
- 6 Serve over arroz blanco.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Dora el pollo. Sofríe el sofrito con tomate, devuelve el pollo con caldo, y 20 minutos después añade papa y calabaza. Sirve con arroz.

Carne Guisada

Stewed beef — sabor a domingo

Makes: 6 servings **Time:** 1½ hrs **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

2 lb beef chuck, cubed

1 sofrito cube (page 7)

1 cup tomato sauce

2 tsp sazón (page 10)

1 tbsp adobo (page 10)

2 potatoes, quartered

1 cup calabaza, cubed

2 tbsp alcaparrado

2½ cups beef broth

3 tbsp olive oil

STEPS

- 1 Season the beef with adobo and sazón.
- 2 Brown well in oil in batches — deep color, deep flavor.
- 3 Cook the sofrito cube 2 minutes; add tomato sauce and alcaparrado.
- 4 Return the beef, add broth, and simmer covered 1 hour.
- 5 Add potatoes and calabaza; simmer 20 minutes until fork-tender.
- 6 Rest 10 minutes, then serve over rice.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Dora bien la carne. Sofríe el sofrito con tomate, añade el caldo y cocina una hora. Luego papa y calabaza otros 20 minutos.

Pernil

Slow-roasted pork shoulder — el plato de Nochebuena

Makes: 12 servings **Time:** 6 hrs + overnight **Level:** Easy, mostly waiting

INGREDIENTS

1 (8 lb) pork shoulder, skin scored

12 garlic cloves, minced

2 tbsp adobo (page 10)

1 tbsp dried oregano

¼ cup olive oil

¼ cup distilled vinegar

Salt & black pepper

STEPS

- 1 Pound the garlic, adobo, oregano and olive oil into a paste; add the vinegar.
- 2 Rub the paste deep into the scored skin and all over the shoulder.
- 3 Cover and marinate in the fridge overnight (12–24 hours).
- 4 Roast at 300°F, uncovered, until fork-tender, 5–6 hours.
- 5 Raise to 450°F for the last 15–20 minutes to crisp the skin.
- 6 Rest 30 minutes, then pull. Serve with arroz con gandules.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Adoba el pernil con la pasta de ajo la noche antes. Asa a 300°F por 5–6 horas hasta que se deshaga. Sube el horno para tostar el cuero y descansa 30 minutos antes de desmenuzar.

Picadillo

Savory ground beef — relleno y plato a la vez

Makes: 4 servings **Time:** 30 min **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

1 lb ground beef

1 sofrito cube (page 7)

½ cup tomato sauce

1 tsp sazón (page 10)

¼ cup alcaparrado

¼ cup raisins (optional)

1 tsp adobo (page 10)

2 tbsp olive oil

STEPS

- 1 Heat the oil; cook the sofrito cube 2 minutes.
- 2 Add the beef and cook, breaking it up, until no longer pink.
- 3 Add tomato sauce, sazón, adobo, alcaparrado and raisins.
- 4 Simmer 10 minutes until the sauce clings to the meat.
- 5 Serve with rice, in empanadas, or as mofongo stuffing.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Sofríe el sofrito, dora la carne molida, añade salsa de tomate, alcaparras y pasas. Hierva suave 10 minutos.

Bacalao Guisado

Stewed salt cod — el sabor de los viernes

Makes: 6 servings **Time:** 45 min + soak **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

1 lb salt cod, soaked overnight, rinsed

1 sofrito cube (page 7)

1 cup tomato sauce

2 potatoes, cubed

2 bell peppers, sliced

1 onion, sliced

2 tbsp alcaparrado

3 tbsp olive oil

½ cup water

STEPS

- 1 Flake the soaked, rinsed cod into pieces; pick out any bones.
- 2 Heat the oil; cook the sofrito cube 2 minutes.
- 3 Add onion and peppers; soften 5 minutes.
- 4 Add tomato sauce, alcaparrado, potatoes and water. Simmer 15 minutes.
- 5 Add the cod and simmer 10 minutes — taste first, the fish is salty.
- 6 Serve with arroz blanco and a slice of aguacate.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Remoja el bacalao la noche anterior. Sofríe el sofrito con cebolla y pimientos, añade tomate, papa y agua; al final el bacalao.

Sancocho

Root-vegetable stew — el caldo de los domingos

Makes: 8 servings **Time:** 1½ hrs **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

1½ lb stew beef or chicken, cubed

1 sofrito cube (page 7)

1 cup calabaza, cubed

1 lb yuca, peeled, cubed

1 lb ñame, peeled, cubed

1 green plantain, cut in chunks

2 ears corn, cut in rounds

2 tsp sazón (page 10)

2 tbsp olive oil

10 cups water

Cilantro for serving

STEPS

- 1 Season and brown the meat in oil over medium-high heat.
- 2 Cook the sofrito cube 2 minutes, then add the water and sazón.
- 3 Simmer, covered, 30 minutes with the corn and calabaza.
- 4 Add yuca, ñame and plantain; simmer 25 more minutes.
- 5 Season to taste. Serve with cilantro on top and a lime wedge.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Dora la carne, sofríe el sofrito, añade agua y luego los viños: maíz, calabaza, yuca, ñame y plátano. Hierva hasta que se ablanden.

Tostones

Twice-fried green plantain — el acompañante frito

Makes: 4 servings **Time:** 30 min **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

2 green plantains

1½ cups canola oil

Salt, flaky

Mojo de ajo (page 11) to serve

STEPS

- 1 Peel the plantains: score the skin lengthwise, pry it off in strips.
- 2 Cut into 1-inch thick rounds.
- 3 Heat the oil to 350°F. Fry the rounds 3–4 minutes until pale gold.
- 4 Drain, then smash each round to ½ inch with a tostonera or plate bottom.
- 5 Fry again 2–3 minutes until golden and crisp.
- 6 Drain, salt generously while hot, and serve with mojo.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Frié los plátanos verdes, aplástalos y fríe de nuevo hasta dorar. Sal al momento y mojo encima.

Amarillos (Maduros)

Sweet ripe plantain — el dulce frito

Makes: 4 servings **Time:** 15 min **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

2 ripe plantains, black-spotted

½ cup canola oil

Pinch of salt

STEPS

- 1 Peel the plantains and slice diagonally into ¾-inch pieces.
- 2 Heat the oil over medium — don't rush this, slow means caramelized.
- 3 Fry 3–4 minutes per side until deep golden and glossy.
- 4 Drain on paper towels and sprinkle with salt.
- 5 Serve alongside rice and beans, or with a fried egg on top.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Fríe el plátano maduro a fuego medio hasta que acaramele. Escurre y sal al momento.

Mofongo

Garlicky smashed plantain — la estrella

Makes: 4 servings **Time:** 45 min **Level:** Medium

INGREDIENTS

4 green plantains

4 garlic cloves

$\frac{1}{3}$ cup olive oil

$\frac{1}{4}$ cup fried pork cracklings (chicharrón), optional

$\frac{1}{2}$ cup chicken broth, warm

Salt

Mojo de ajo (page 11) to serve

STEPS

- 1 Peel and cut the plantains into $1\frac{1}{2}$ -inch rounds. Fry in oil until golden and soft.
- 2 Pound the garlic with salt into a paste in a mortar (pilón) or bowl.
- 3 Add the fried plantains in batches with the pork cracklings and pound while drizzling olive oil.
- 4 Add warm broth to loosen — the mix should hold its shape.
- 5 Mold into balls or pack into a bowl and unmold.
- 6 Serve with mojo de ajo drizzled on top and a broth.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Frié los plátanos verdes, machácalos en el pilón con ajo, chicharrón y aceite; afloja con caldo. Sirve con mojo.

Alcapurrias

Root-vegetable fritters, meat-filled — la fritura de la esquina

Makes: 8 fritters **Time:** 1½ hrs **Level:** Medium

INGREDIENTS

3 green plantains, peeled, cubed

1 lb yautía, peeled, cubed

1 cup calabaza, cubed

2 cups picadillo (page 21), cooled

2 tbsp annatto oil

1 tsp salt

2 cups canola oil, for frying

STEPS

- 1 Grate the plantains, yautía and calabaza fine (food processor works).
- 2 Mix with salt and annatto oil into a firm, pasty dough.
- 3 Wet your hands. Shape a ball, press a well, fill with 2 tbsp picadillo.
- 4 Seal into a fat oval, pinched at both ends.
- 5 Fry at 350°F, turning, until deep brown and crisp, 8–10 minutes.
- 6 Drain on paper towels and serve hot.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Raya el plátano, yautía y calabaza; haz la masa con sal y aceite de achiote. Rellena con picadillo y fríe bien doradas.

Bacalaitos

Salt-cod fritters — el crujido de la playa

Makes: 12 fritters **Time:** 40 min + soak **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

1 cup salt cod, soaked overnight, flaked

1 cup all-purpose flour

¼ cup cornmeal

1 cup water

1 small onion, minced

2 garlic cloves, minced

1 tsp adobo (page 10)

2 cups canola oil, for frying

STEPS

- 1 Whisk flour, cornmeal and water into a loose batter.
- 2 Fold in the cod, onion, garlic and adobo. It should be thin, not doughy.
- 3 Heat the oil to 350°F.
- 4 Ladle thin rounds of batter into the oil, a few at a time.
- 5 Fry 2–3 minutes per side until golden and lacy at the edges.
- 6 Drain, salt lightly, and serve with a squeeze of lime.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Mezcla harina y maíz con agua, añade el bacalao, cebolla y ajo. Vierte rondas delgadas en aceite caliente y fríe dorado.

Sorullos

Cornmeal sticks — con queso adentro si te atreves

Makes: 10 sticks **Time:** 30 min **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

1½ cups cornmeal

1½ cups water

1 tsp salt

1 tbsp sugar

1 cup queso blanco or mozzarella, in sticks (optional)

2 cups canola oil, for frying

STEPS

- 1 Bring water, salt and sugar to a boil; whisk in the cornmeal.
- 2 Stir until it pulls away from the pot and forms a soft dough, 3 minutes.
- 3 Cool until handleable. Shape into 4-inch logs around a cheese stick, if using.
- 4 Fry at 350°F until deep golden, 4–5 minutes.
- 5 Drain and serve with garlic mayo or as a side to any guiso.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Hierve agua con sal y azúcar, agrega la harina de maíz hasta formar masa. Forma palitos, con queso si quieres, y fríe.

Pasteles

Banana-leaf tamales — el trabajo de amor navideño

Makes: 12 pasteles **Time:** 3 hrs **Level:** Medium, worth it

INGREDIENTS

2 lb green bananas, peeled, grated

1 lb yautía, peeled, grated

1 cup calabaza, grated

2 cups picadillo (page 21), cooled

⅓ cup annatto oil

1 cup chicken broth

12 banana-leaf squares, softened

Salt

STEPS

- 1 Mix the grated banana, yautía and calabaza with salt, broth and annatto oil into a thick masa.
- 2 Lay a leaf square over a piece of parchment. Spoon on 3 tbsp masa.
- 3 Top with 2 tbsp picadillo and fold the masa around it.
- 4 Wrap tightly into a neat packet, parchment then leaf; tie with kitchen string.
- 5 Boil a big pot of water; simmer the pasteles 45–50 minutes.
- 6 Unwrap and serve hot alongside pernil and arroz con gandules.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Raya plátano, yautía y calabaza; haz la masa con aceite de achiote. Rellena con picadillo, envuelve en hojas y hierva 50 minutos.

Coquito

Puerto Rican eggnog — el brindis de la Navidad

Makes: 6 cups **Time:** 15 min **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

1 can coconut milk

1 can cream of coconut

1 can sweetened condensed milk

1 can evaporated milk

1 tsp vanilla

1 tsp ground cinnamon

¼ tsp nutmeg

1½ cups white rum (optional, to taste)

STEPS

- 1 Blend the coconut milk, cream of coconut, condensed and evaporated milk.
- 2 Add vanilla, cinnamon and nutmeg; blend until smooth.
- 3 Stir in rum to taste — it's a family decision, honestly.
- 4 Chill at least 2 hours. Shake or stir before serving.
- 5 Pour, dust with cinnamon, and toast the family.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Licúa las cuatro leches con vainilla, canela y nuez moscada. Añade el ron, enfría y sirve espolvoreado con canela.

Arroz con Dulce

Coconut rice pudding — el dulce de la mesa

Makes: 8 servings **Time:** 1 hr + chill **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

1 cup medium-grain rice

2 cans coconut milk

1 cup water

$\frac{3}{4}$ cup sugar

$\frac{1}{2}$ cup raisins

2 cinnamon sticks

4 whole cloves

1 tbsp ginger, grated

Ground cinnamon to finish

STEPS

- 1 Rinse the rice. In a pot, combine rice, water, cinnamon, cloves and ginger.
- 2 Simmer, uncovered, until the rice is tender and most liquid is absorbed, 20 minutes.
- 3 Add the coconut milk, sugar and raisins. Stir over medium until thick and creamy, 15–20 minutes.
- 4 Cool, then chill at least 4 hours — it thickens as it rests.
- 5 Serve cold in bowls, dusted with cinnamon.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Hierve el arroz con canela, clavos y jengibre; añade leche de coco, azúcar y pasas hasta espesar. Enfría y sirve frío.

Ensalada de Coditos

Boricua macaroni salad — nunca falta en la mesa

Makes: 8 servings **Time:** 30 min **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

1 lb elbow macaroni

1½ cups mayonnaise

1 cup peas (thawed, if frozen)

½ cup pimientos or roasted red pepper, diced

½ cup green olives, sliced

2 stalks celery, diced

1 small onion, minced

Salt & pepper

STEPS

- 1 Boil the macaroni until al dente. Drain and rinse with cold water.
- 2 In a big bowl, mix the mayonnaise, peas, pimientos, olives, celery and onion.
- 3 Fold in the cooled macaroni and season with salt and pepper.
- 4 Chill at least 2 hours — better the next day.
- 5 Serve cold beside pernil, pasteles, or just by the spoonful.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Hierve los coditos, mezcla con mayonesa, guisantes, pimientos, aceitunas, apio y cebolla. Enfría bien y sirve.

Tembleque

Coconut pudding that shakes — el postre que tiembla

Makes: 8 servings **Time:** 20 min + chill **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

4 cups coconut milk

½ cup cornstarch

¾ cup sugar

1 tsp vanilla

1 pinch salt

Ground cinnamon to finish

STEPS

- 1 Whisk a little of the coconut milk into the cornstarch to dissolve it.
- 2 In a pot, combine the remaining milk, sugar and salt; bring to a gentle simmer.
- 3 Whisk in the cornstarch slurry; stir constantly until it thickens, 5–7 minutes.
- 4 Stir in the vanilla, then pour into a wetted mold or glasses.
- 5 Chill 4+ hours until set — it should jiggle when tapped.
- 6 Unmold and dust with cinnamon. Serve cold.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Disuelve la maicena en leche de coco tibia, espesa con azúcar y vainilla. Vacía en moldes, enfría 4 horas y espolvorea canela.

Flan de Coco

Coconut caramel custard — el favorito de la abuela

Makes: 10 servings **Time:** 1½ hrs **Level:** Medium

INGREDIENTS

1 cup sugar (for the caramel)

1 can coconut milk

1 can evaporated milk

1 can sweetened condensed milk

5 eggs

1 tsp vanilla

1 cup toasted coconut, to finish

STEPS

- 1 Melt the sugar in a pan over medium until amber; pour into a flan mold, coating the bottom.
- 2 Blend the coconut milk, evaporated and condensed milks, eggs and vanilla until smooth.
- 3 Pour over the caramel. Cover the mold with foil.
- 4 Set in a water bath and bake at 350°F until just set, about 1 hour.
- 5 Cool, then chill overnight. Unmold over the caramel sauce.
- 6 Top with toasted coconut and serve cold.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Carameliza el azúcar en el molde. Licúa las leches con los huevos y vainilla, hornea al baño de maría una hora, y enfría toda la noche.

Limonada de Parcha

Passion-fruit lemonade — el refresco del verano

Makes: 6 cups **Time:** 10 min **Level:** Easy

INGREDIENTS

1 cup parcha (passion fruit) pulp, fresh or frozen

½ cup lime juice

¾ cup sugar

4 cups cold water

Lime slices & mint to serve

STEPS

- 1 Whisk the sugar into the water until dissolved.
- 2 Stir in the parcha pulp and lime juice.
- 3 Taste — add more sugar if the parcha is tart.
- 4 Chill over ice and serve with lime and mint.
- 5 Straight to the porch, where it belongs.

EN ESPAÑOL · THE SHORT VERSION

Mezcla agua fría con azúcar, agrega la pulpa de parcha y el jugo de limón. Sirve bien fría.

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